have also seen swings between textualism and realism, often to our detriment. Some of the historical accounts of negotiations bring out how China used inexactitude to give itself more wiggle room. At the same time, major policy changes have also been effected by simply dismissing the past. Extracting ritualistic affirmations from the other side on concerns has been one way of playing the game. India has however been more reciprocal in seeking commitments of late. Today, the bottomline for the relationship is clear: peace and tranquillity must prevail on the border if the progress made in the last three decades is not to be jeopardized. The border and the future of ties cannot be separated.

For new ground to be broken, much more is needed on the positive side of the ledger. But it is equally important to guard against unilateral actions that increase volatility. While the centrality of the border factor has been long recognized, their activities and interests in global politics will now have a greater relevance in the overall calculation. We have to distinguish here the normal interplay of nations in international politics from a more focused effort at creating an equilibrium. When the logic of power is viewed through the lens of realism, China will advance its objectives and exploit its edge. In turn, India must respond unemotionally but effectively, especially when presented with challenging situations. We have always assumed that a more substantive relationship would naturally be a more stable one. Recent trends underline that this should not be taken as a given. Instead, each should strive to occupy a greater mind space of the other.

India is not the only country focused on coming to terms with a significantly more powerful China. In fact, the entire world is doing so, each nation refashioning its terms of engagement in its own way. If there is a common approach, it is of them simultaneously strengthening capacities internally, assessing the external landscape and seeking understandings with China. In this overall exercise, India will occupy a special place by virtue of its size, location, potential, history and culture. The key to a more settled Sino-Indian relationship is a greater acceptance by both countries of multipolarity and mutuality, building on a larger foundation of global rebalancing.